
She Was the Queen of Aughts Controversy. A New Book Shows How Much Harm It All Did.

Published by

Scaachi Koul

Estimated reading time

10 min

Added on

2026-04-15

Address

<https://slate.com/culture/2026/04/lena-dunham-book-famesick-review.html>

She Was the Queen of Aughts Controversy. A New Book Shows How Much Harm It All Did.

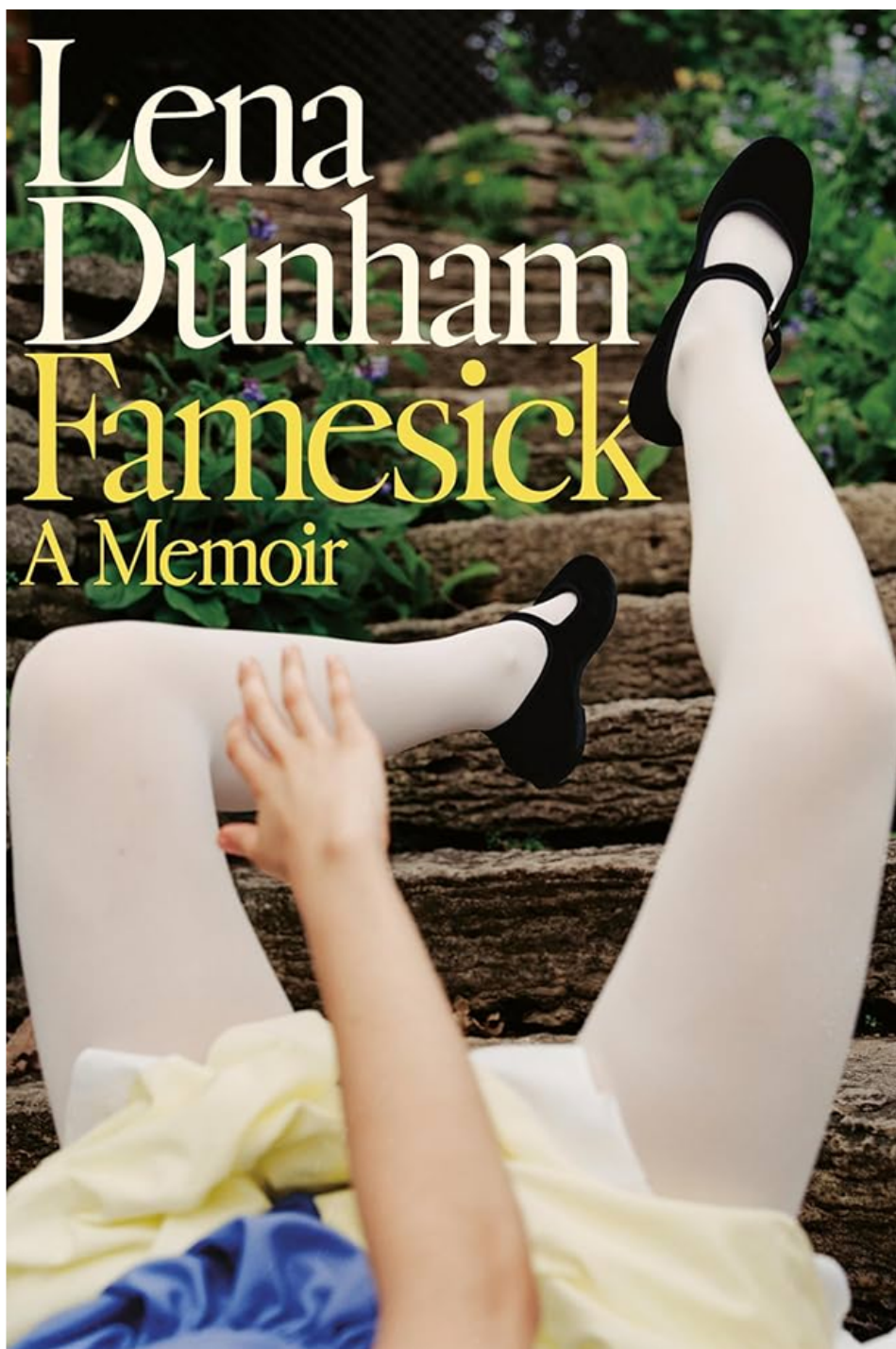
For most of the 2010s, everything was Lena Dunham's fault. She was responsible for the failures of feminism, of millennials, of white people, of white women, of [nepo babies](#) (before we even had the term), the oversexualization of women on television, for "[hipster racism](#)," and of course, for [Taylor Swift](#). She was a writer and an actor, but was instead treated with the same righteousness you may reserve for a war criminal. Only in hindsight does it seem like Dunham was perhaps given too much credit.

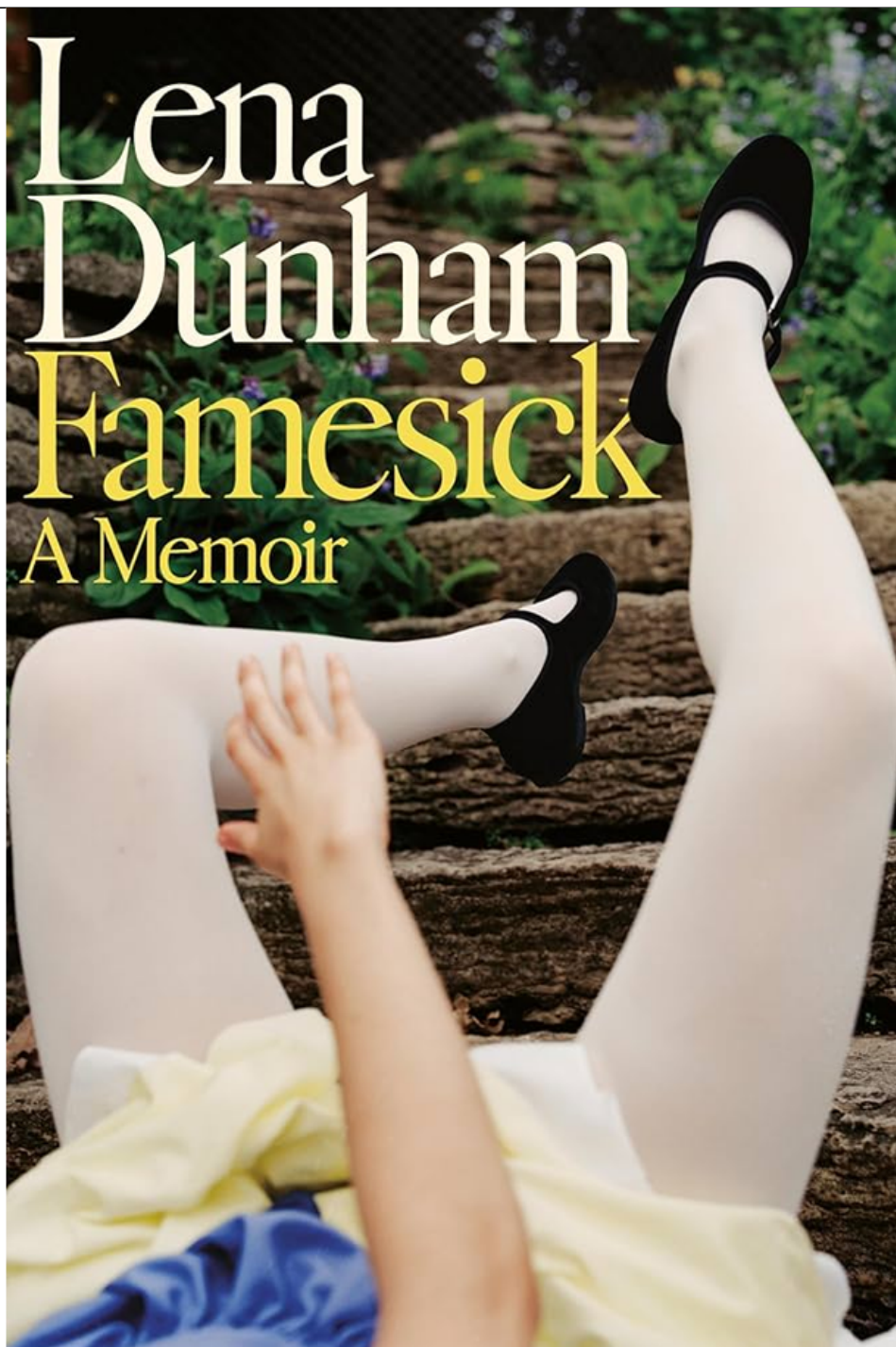
In the 15 years that Dunham has been in the public eye, her work has taken many forms but is always imbued with an aggressive and profitable controversy. It's been a little less than a decade since Dunham's HBO show *Girls* ended its six-season run, and a little more than a decade since she published her first book, *Not That Kind of Girl: A Young Woman Tells You What She's "Learned."* She launched a [newsletter](#) before everyone started doing it, she made another, less beloved [HBO show](#), and then, for a while, mostly disappeared from day-to-day press. Dunham was [still working](#) and perfectly accessible, through her Instagram and Twitter back when it was called that, but after a decade of unbearable overexposure, she moved to London and got quiet.

This week, Dunham returns to the confessional with a new memoir, [Famesick](#), which follows her while she seeks and eschews fame, while also becoming more and more physically and mentally ill. The book starts with Dunham making *Tiny Furniture*, the film that kick-started her career, all the way through the production of *Girls*, the release and death of Lenny Letter, her several cancellations (some deserved, some deeply stupid), a Klonopin addiction, countless surgeries, some of the worst men that New York and Los Angeles have to offer, through to her current life in London. It's a memoir about a woman insistent on slamming her body and spirit into a brick wall in the name of capitalism and commercial artistic success, someone who couldn't bring herself to say no to a single work opportunity while her health was steadily deteriorating. Forever overpromising and underdelivering—to her friends who needed her attention, to her co-workers who needed her presence, to her family who was steadily tiring of her refusal to take care of herself—Dunham, in *Famesick*, recasts many of her public controversies in the context of her raucous illnesses, a bloodthirsty tabloid press, and an unforgiving audience.

Famesick is an ideal celebrity memoir with the added bonus of being written by someone who can actually write. Both the memoir and Dunham remain lightly enamored with celebrity, name-dropping just enough (Oprah, "Scott fucking Speedman," Judd Apatow, and Bruce Springsteen, who essentially tells her to get a grip at a dinner party) to keep you drooling for more. But it's also a shocking and funny read, clear-eyed and contextualized, a testament to what made her so interesting in the first place and why her work has always been so compelling. But most importantly, *Famesick* is an attestation to the value of slowing down, going home, and shutting the fuck up so you have something to say again.

If you've hated Dunham this whole time and resented her success, well, good news: *Famesick* will tell you just how awful all that success made her feel. "There were always new people to disappoint, new ways to fail, new bars not to clear," she writes. "I wanted, I know now, to be loving and loved, to be needed and necessary, to be so generous that I was above censure and so kind that I was above being subjected to anyone's cruelty." Impossible, and so instead Dunham let everyone run over her. Her body and brain had no value without a show, without being invited to the right parties, without being a name. She ignored her own instincts, rapacious for visible success instead of





[Famesick](#)

By Lean Dunham. Random House.

[\\$21 from Amazon](#)

[\\$29.82 from Bookshop](#)

Slate receives a commission when you purchase items using the links on this page. Thank you for your support.

In retelling her story, Dunham is no longer the 25-year-old responsible for the entire context of the midaughts. She's shrunk down to regular size, a young woman working with people who didn't particularly care for her. When she loses weight while taping *Girls*, her co-showrunner and best friend Jenni Konner tells her she needs to gain it back. "It's not funny if you're too thin," Konner tells her. "It's not that hard. Just put food in your mouth." At the time, Dunham was juggling an eating disorder that would continue to rule some of her life for the next decade. When Konner catches her eating pizza, she praises her with "Good girl." Konner is, throughout the book, a modest bad guy—someone who helped Dunham get where she is today but who took advantage of her desire to keep Konner content.

Because that's what Dunham wanted to be: endeared and praised, told she was doing a good job while it was literally killing her. Even if mired in constant drama, she always wanted to be liked, approved of, maybe adored, even to her own detriment. "Sometimes, I'm sure, I was straight up begging for an ounce of praise to erase the ache that came from filling my head with other people's disdain," she writes. She wanted to be seen, like everyone does, but in that pursuit—Vogue shoots, hosting *Saturday Night Live*, promotion for *Girls* on late-night television, pawing at men for approval when they didn't give a shit about her—she stopped seeing herself. "It makes me laugh now thinking how much trouble I must have cooked up in my twenties by being radically myself, when in reality, I was universes away from my own body," she writes. "It's easy to set fires in a life that seems like a simulation."

Her commodification, perpetrated by agents and networks and friends and, of course, Dunham herself, served only to make her sicker. Most gutting are Dunham's description of her endless medical catastrophes, including a hysterectomy and an Ehlers-Danlos syndrome diagnosis. Doctors find more than 30 lesions in her body during a surgery, which impact her ability to walk or even live without pain. She writes about the "chocolate cyst" doctors find in her ovaries, she breaks her elbow during a *Girls* shoot and throws her arm in a shitty sling to make it through the shoot, she pops pain pills just to make it through her endless workdays. "I had nothing to offer," she writes. "I was tapped out, drained, emotionally mined until all the oil dried up and the drillers had moved on to a new continent." Her rewards, though enormous, paled in comparison to her physical pain, her emotional distress, her constant alienation. She just couldn't get out of her own way. She kept offering to the altar of public attention, hoping to explain herself enough to make us love her.

Dunham is still happy to tell you pretty much everything, with two small exceptions. Even now, she refuses the nepo baby label, arguing that her parents are obscure New York City artists and not television bigwigs who shuffled their untalented daughter to the HBO offices. True, but not entirely honest: When Dunham needed representation in her mid-20s after she pitched *Girls*, her mother called an old friend to ask for help. The friend was an original founder of United Talent Agency, one of the big three talent agencies in the country. Dunham is unavoidably connected, a city kid with access to people with real connections. Her former babysitter? Zac Posen.

The other gap is from 2017, when one of the writers of *Girls* was accused of sexually assaulting a 17-year-old girl. Konner and Dunham released a statement defending him, calling the accusations "one of the 3 percent of assault cases that are misreported every year. It is a true shame to add to that number, as outside of Hollywood women still struggle to be believed." Dunham writes now that, at the time, she was high, hiding an opioid and benzodiazepine addiction, allowing Konner and the other grown-ups in the room to draft much of that response. On this, Dunham is roiling with regret,

so deep in her shame that she can't even tell you what it is she did; you'll have to Google it yourself. Maybe it's because she remembers so little of that time—she was popping Klonopin and Percocet, floating above reality, unwilling to fully confront the worst thing she's ever done (her words). Konner and her are now estranged; that breakup—and not the ones with any men—is the soft, sad thrum of lamentation running through the memoir.

Famesick doesn't have heroes or villains, just several people trying their best and still failing. Konner takes most of the heat, a representative of all the work Dunham had to do while fighting for her life in hospital beds between New York and Los Angeles. Her ex-boyfriend, Jack Antonoff, is sometimes a charming, supportive partner who sees Dunham clearly and adores her. Eventually, he becomes a disinterested boyfriend who can't put up with her medical bullshit anymore. (She does, however, mention the infamous [PowerPoint presentation](#) about how he was perhaps having an emotional affair with Lorde, a delicious reminder that celebrities are just as vulnerable to gossip as the rest of us.) Her heartbreak is palpable, her loneliness vibrational. There's a reason why people loved *Girls* even when they hated it: No one can encapsulate the ego-crushing and spirit-deflating and heart-shattering that comes with a guy who can't give you what you so desperately need, want, deserve like Dunham.

Related From Slate



[Laura Miller](#)

[She Taught Women How to Orgasm. Decades Later, Her Impact Can Still Be Felt.](#)

[Read More](#)

Near the end of *Famesick*, Dunham admits that the invites to the Met Gala have ceased. She's less popular among famous people, and less sought-after. In exchange? People are inviting her to their weddings again. We get less of her, and she gets less of us. "What would happen if I took some time not at my rock bottom, or during a health crisis, but just because it was an important thing to do?" she writes. "A crisis only arises if you're expecting a smooth journey. I was still reaching for the idea that some things could just be."

In 2021, when she won an Emmy for *I May Destroy You*, actor and writer Michaela Coel gave an acceptance speech mostly about the value of quietude. "In a world that entices us to browse through the lives of others to help us better determine how we feel about ourselves, and to in turn, feel the need to be constantly visible, for visibility these days seems to somehow equate to

success,” she said, “do not be afraid to disappear. From it, from us, for a while, and see what comes to you in the silence.”

Dunham never fully disappeared; she was always making something, always quietly industrious, and always chipping away at herself here and there in the process. But she has learned to give us less of herself, to keep the pieces for her own use instead of our projection. In leaving, she made more room to come back with a firmer sense of self, less shaken by a sometimes-vicious and sometimes-honest public, and more capable of giving herself the silence that lets her make good art. In returning, she gives us another chance to exercise some compassion, some restraint, and a bit of understanding that we helped make her sick too.

Get the best of culture

Get the best of movies, TV, books, music, and more.

Thanks for signing up! You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

You're already subscribed to the Culture newsletter. You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

We encountered an issue signing you up. Please try again, or [manage all your newsletter subscriptions here](#) .

Please enable javascript to sign up for newsletters.

Email address:

Send me updates about Slate special offers.

By signing up, you agree to our [Privacy Policy](#) and [Terms](#).

Sign Up

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.